

Internship Key Learnings

Goal of the Internship, Department Rotations, and Friday Bonus Courses

Goal of the Internship

This internship was built around one central goal, which was to give interns a complete, ground level understanding of how a real B2B software company operates, not just from one department, but from every department that touches the customer, the product, and the business itself. Rather than being placed in a single team for the entire summer, interns rotated weekly through nearly every function of Evisions, a higher education software company, including product and UX, engineering and quality assurance, professional services, marketing, support and security, finance and human resources, and customer success and sales.

The reasoning behind this structure was straightforward. Most early career professionals only ever see the department they are hired into, and they rarely understand how their work connects to the rest of the company. This internship was designed to close that gap before a career even begins. Each week paired real department work, including sitting in on actual meetings, building real product artifacts, and working through real case studies, with a Friday set of bonus sessions focused specifically on professional development. Those Friday sessions covered business fundamentals, communication skills, philanthropy, and relationship building, and they ran in parallel with the department rotations for the entire summer.

The internship also centered on one ongoing project throughout every week, the Social Engagement Accelerator, a dashboard product that aggregates student social data across a campus to help identify socially isolated or at risk students early. Using one consistent product as the throughline meant that every department rotation, from product strategy to engineering to sales, could be taught in the context of the same real product, rather than as disconnected lessons. The internship concluded with a capstone presentation, requiring interns to synthesize everything learned across every department into a single, cohesive understanding of how a company takes an idea from a market opportunity all the way through to a paying, renewing customer.

Department Rotations

The sections below cover each week of the internship, organized by department. Each section includes the department's overview and purpose, the key topics and skills covered, and the most important insights from that week.

Week 1: Product Management, UX, and the Software Development Life Cycle

Department overview and purpose

- The Product and UX teams represent the customer and are responsible for identifying who the customers are, what problems they have, and building products people are willing to pay for
- The project studied throughout the internship is the Social Engagement Accelerator (SEA), a dashboard that aggregates student social data across campus to identify at risk or isolated students and enable staff intervention
- Evisions is a company with more than twenty five years of experience exclusively in higher education software, known for strong customer support, with flagship products including Argos, Argos X, and Data Agent

Key topics and skills

- Market segmentation in higher education, since a community college and an Ivy League school share almost nothing operationally
- Primary versus secondary research, and the value of triangulating a claim across an interview and a published source
- Grooming meetings, where product teams scope tickets before handing them to engineering or UX
- Agile versus waterfall development, Kanban boards, and the Product Introduction Checklist phases from idea through post launch
- Data sourcing challenges in higher education, including fragmented systems and privacy constraints such as FERPA and HIPAA
- Roadmapping fundamentals, including minimum viable product definition, the time cost scope triangle, and the parking lot concept for deferred features
- UX fundamentals, including designing for the least technical user, Gestalt principles, Nielsen Norman heuristics, and System Usability Scale scoring

Insights

- Getting the market opportunity wrong dooms even excellent engineering, since everything else depends on solving the right problem
- The people who build a product are not always the people who buy it, so messaging must be calibrated to the actual audience

Week 2: Software Engineering, Quality Assurance, and Test Automation

Department overview and purpose

- Engineering is responsible for delivering the right software at the right time, balancing scope against team capacity
- Quality assurance is not just testing, it is the discipline of building quality into every stage of development rather than catching problems only at the end

Key topics and skills

- Scope versus capacity negotiation, and how reducing scope is a form of prioritization rather than failure
- The Scrum framework, including sprint planning, daily stand ups, sprint review, and retrospectives
- Frontend versus backend development basics, covering HTML, CSS, JavaScript, application programming interfaces, authentication, and create, read, update, delete operations
- On premises, cloud, and hybrid deployment models, and their tradeoffs in cost, control, and scalability
- Functional, integration, platform, performance, and security testing
- Exploratory testing, including writing a testing charter and the tourist metaphor for organizing test coverage by area of the product
- AI guardrails, including human in the loop review, visibility of AI generated content, and avoiding autonomous action on high risk operations
- Accessibility and localization testing standards, including Web Content Accessibility Guidelines compliance

Insights

- AI is most useful for well defined, structured tasks such as application programming interface testing, and struggles with legacy or proprietary tooling
- Ad hoc testing produces results that cannot be reproduced, while a documented, time boxed charter produces coverage that compounds over time

Week 3: Professional Services, Partnerships, and Argos Training

Department overview and purpose

- Professional Services delivers training, consulting, development, and implementation for clients who lack the time or expertise to do the work themselves
- The Partnerships team acts as connective tissue between Evisions departments and outside partners, evaluating opportunities for product relevance, revenue potential, and partner readiness

Key topics and skills

- The distinction between training a client to use a tool and building the client's specific deliverable for them
- Reseller versus technology partnerships, and how termination clauses protect both sides when circumstances change
- Deep, hands on training in Argos, including data blocks, dashboard objects, banded reports, bands, templates, and library objects
- Building reusable templates and styles to standardize branding and reduce setup time across future reports

Insights

- Higher education clients tend to adopt new technology more slowly, which shapes how AI and new tools are introduced in this market
 - A well negotiated contract, even one that feels unnecessary at signing, protects both parties if circumstances change unexpectedly
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Week 4: Marketing, Sales, and Communications

Department overview and purpose

- Marketing promotes and communicates the value of a product to a target audience through branding, content, email, social media, events, and website strategy

Key topics and skills

- Buyer personas, brand voice, and the customer journey from awareness to loyalty
- Content marketing pillars, storytelling, and distribution channels
- Email marketing anatomy, including subject lines, calls to action, and audience segmentation
- Social media strategy and visual branding consistency
- Event marketing planning, budgeting, and measuring success
- Website design principles, including user experience, landing pages, and search engine optimization

Insights

- Revenue comes from creating value, meaning the perceived gap between a customer's current state and what the product delivers is what determines whether a sale closes
 - Effective selling is consultative rather than transactional, built on curiosity and asking better questions rather than talking the most
 - Preparation and authentic curiosity in interviews and professional conversations build trust faster than trying to appear impressive
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Week 5: Support, DevOps, and Cybersecurity

Department overview and purpose

- Support resolves customer issues quickly and communicates clearly, with a defined boundary between free support and billable Professional Services work
- DevOps and Security protect the company's systems and guide decision making during security incidents

Key topics and skills

- Core customer service attributes, including active listening, empathy, and knowing when to escalate
- Salesforce as the central customer relationship management system, case queues, and JIRA integration for defects
- Using AI as a support tool while maintaining ownership of accuracy, since responsibility for a wrong answer stays with the analyst, not the tool
- Service level agreement design, including priority tiers and escalation frameworks
- AI security threats, including prompt injection, model poisoning, and shadow AI

- Compliance standards, including SOC 2, ISO 27001, HIPAA, GDPR, and FERPA
- A tabletop exercise walking through how a company should respond to a ransomware attack

Insights

- AI expands what a support or operations professional can attempt, but it still produces confident, incorrect answers and requires human validation before anything is published
 - The decision to pay or not pay a ransom involves far more than financial math, including reputation, customer trust, and legal obligations
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Week 6: Finance, Accounting, and Human Resources

Department overview and purpose

- Finance is forward looking and uses accounting data to project the business, while accounting is backward looking and records what already happened
- Human Resources, often called People and Culture internally, covers recruiting, onboarding, compensation, performance management, and legal compliance

Key topics and skills

- The corporate budgeting cycle, fixed versus variable expenses, and building a revenue forecast using existing base, new bookings, pricing increases, and churn
- Total addressable market estimation using top down, bottom up, and value theory approaches
- Cost of sales, gross margin, and categories of operating expenses
- The thirty, sixty, ninety day onboarding framework and the hiring process from job analysis through offer
- 401k mechanics, including employer match, vesting, and the difference between pre tax and Roth contributions

Insights

- Plans are useless but planning is indispensable, meaning the discipline of forecasting matters even when the exact numbers change
 - Starting retirement contributions early matters more than the amount contributed, due to the power of compounding growth over time
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Week 7: Customer Success, Feedback Design, and Sales Technical Teams

Department overview and purpose

- The Customer Success Team sits between Support and Professional Services, offering consultative guidance and advocating for customer needs internally
- Solutions Engineers own the technical side of a sale, validating that a solution will actually work for a prospect's specific environment

Key topics and skills

- Designing feedback mechanisms using four principles, being specific, anchoring in a concrete feature, asking diagnostic questions, and focusing on the work rather than the person

- The feedback lifecycle, plan, launch, collect, analyze, and act, and why closing the loop with participants matters
- The art of a software demonstration, including telling a story rather than giving a tour, and preparing for unexpected questions honestly
- The value wedge concept for sales messaging, meaning a claim should be important to the prospect, unique to the vendor, and defensible with proof
- Emotional intelligence in sales, including qualifying opportunities and distinguishing constructive persuasion from adversarial pushback

Insights

- Products built without early customer feedback generate more confusion after launch than products tested early with real users
 - Trust is built by admitting uncertainty and following up with an accurate answer, rather than pretending to know everything
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Friday Bonus Courses: The Overarching Goal Behind Each Track

Every Friday throughout the internship included bonus sessions that ran outside the main department rotation. At first glance these sessions might look like an unrelated mix of topics, business one week, communications the next, philanthropy scattered throughout, and relationship building woven into nearly everything. In reality, each track was built toward one specific, consistent goal across the entire summer. The explanations below describe what each track was actually trying to teach, why the sessions were sequenced the way they were, and why the track matters for someone early in their career.

Business: Understanding How a Company Actually Creates and Protects Value

The overarching goal of the business track was to take the abstract idea of how a company works and make it concrete by showing how every department at Evisions contributes to one shared outcome, which is creating value for a customer and then protecting that value over time.

Early sessions in this track introduced the basic mechanics, such as how a business to business software company is structured and how money flows between departments like sales, product, engineering, and finance. Later sessions built directly on that foundation by introducing the people responsible for revenue, then the people responsible for hiring the right talent, then the people responsible for legal risk and contracts. By the end of the internship, the business track had walked through nearly every major function of the company, not as isolated topics, but as connected pieces of the same machine.

This matters because most early career professionals only ever see the department they are hired into, and they rarely understand how their work connects to the rest of the company. This track was designed to close that gap before a career even begins. It repeatedly returned to two central ideas: first, that no single team creates value alone, since value is created through handoffs between departments, and second, that leadership is fundamentally about making the best possible decision with incomplete information and then learning quickly from the outcome. Every guest speaker, whether discussing sales revenue or corporate budgeting, reinforced these same two ideas from a different angle, and that repetition was intentional, meant to make the concept stick as a lens for understanding how any company operates, not just Evisions.

Communications: Learning to Be Remembered, Not Just Understood

The overarching goal of the communications track was to teach one core skill, which is how to become memorable and trustworthy in any professional conversation, whether that conversation is a job interview, a sales call, or a casual introduction to someone senior.

This track deliberately avoided teaching communication as a set of scripted answers to memorize. Instead, every session broke communication down into a repeatable structure that could flex to fit any situation. Early sessions introduced foundational frameworks, such as the STAR method for answering behavioral interview questions and the idea of preparing a small set of adaptable personal stories in advance. Later sessions built on that foundation with more advanced techniques, such as researching a person in advance to find the one subject they cannot help but talk about, or using silence intentionally so an answer feels more confident rather than rushed.

What ties all of these sessions together is a single underlying philosophy, which is that people remember how a conversation made them feel, not the specific words that were said. A candidate who rambles through a rehearsed answer is forgettable, while a candidate who listens closely, answers directly, and shows real curiosity about the other person is remembered long after the conversation ends. This track existed specifically to give interns that skill before they need it in a real interview or a real client meeting, since confidence in conversation is not something most people are born with, it is something that can be practiced and built through repetition, which is exactly why nearly every communications session ended with an actual practice exercise rather than only a lecture.

Philanthropy: Understanding That Giving Is a Discipline, Not Just an Instinct

The overarching goal of the philanthropy track was to replace a simple, feel good idea of charity with a much more accurate and detailed understanding of how giving actually works as a structured, professional field.

This track was built in a deliberate progression. It started with the basics, defining terms such as time, treasure, and talent, and walking through the history and purpose of philanthropy in general. From there, it introduced the difference between a nonprofit, which runs its own programs and must fundraise its own operating money, and a foundation, which exists specifically to fund other organizations through grants. Once that foundation of vocabulary was in place, later sessions went much deeper, covering how foundations are legally required to give away a minimum percentage of their assets every year, how grant applications are actually reviewed and scored, and how corporate giving fits into a broader framework known as Corporate Social Responsibility. The track closed with a direct conversation with two real foundation founders, who spoke candidly about how difficult it actually is to choose between multiple deserving applicants.

This track was structured this way because philanthropy is often misunderstood as something simple, meaning a person or company simply decides to be generous and writes a check. This track was designed to correct that misunderstanding. It showed that giving well requires the same rigor as running a business, including budgeting, compliance, measuring impact, and making hard tradeoffs between competing priorities. By the time interns heard directly from the foundation founders in the final week, they already had the vocabulary and context to understand why those founders described their decisions as genuinely difficult, rather than simply hearing that difficulty described in the abstract.

Connections: Building the Habit of Genuine Relationship Building Early in a Career

The overarching goal of the connections theme, which was woven throughout the internship rather than taught as one single standalone track, was to instill one specific habit, which is treating every professional relationship as something worth investing in intentionally, starting from the very beginning of a career rather than waiting until it feels necessary.

This theme showed up in multiple forms across the summer. It appeared in the business sessions, where speakers described their own career paths as anything but a straight line, moving between industries and even being let go before rebuilding, which was meant to show interns that an unconventional path is not a failure. It appeared in the communications sessions, where the technique of researching a person's genuine interests before a conversation was framed specifically as relationship building, not just interview preparation. It also appeared in the way departments themselves were introduced, since nearly every

speaker made a point of explaining how their team depended on strong relationships with other teams in order to do their job well.

This theme was repeated often, rather than taught in a single dedicated session, because relationship building is not really a skill that can be taught in one sitting. It has to be modeled repeatedly, in different contexts, until it becomes a habit rather than a technique. The consistent message across every version of this theme was that the people met early in a career, including the people met during an internship, are often the same people who will refer, hire, or open a door years later, so the effort put into genuinely knowing them now is rarely wasted.